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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1998-1999

Coverage Date: 1998 AD - 1999 AD

Place Coverage

Mgeta and Nyandira, Mvomero, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S)

Competition and Reciprocity in the First Holy Communion Ceremony

This signals the next to last stage of the ceremony in which the healer asked for four people from four different clans, 2 maternal lineages and 2 paternal, as stated by Baba Mwenda, "the four people who have touched him in his birth." These men and women are asked by the healer whether or not they have any complaints about the person's behavior. One by one they hold a tall stick and stand in front of the initiates, saying whatever is on their mind. Baba Mwenda explained, "In my case, they would choose people from my mother's and father's sides who know something about my character. Maybe when they arrive at my home, I sulk, or my wife also is not cheerful.¹⁶ These things they *must* mention." No matter what happens or the kind of complaints that are delivered (these may be significant, especially since cross-cousins are joking partners), the person must sit without reaction. Baba Mwenda continued, "During this time "you cannot scowl, or despise them or get angry." (also see Mzuanda 1958:110). Finally, with this public approval, the temporary bracelets that the husband and wife wore before receiving their *mhande* are broken off the wrist, they are secured with a nut from the forest that is bit into by a member of the clan from which the name was taken.

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At the culmination of the ceremony, a chicken is paraded 7 times around the house to song and drums, and then the *Mwenye Mlungu* proceed inside with the initiates who are given their final instructions. Next to a vat of beer, seven elders hold the chicken, with hands on top of each other, and perform the last (secret) part of this ceremony (hint: the chicken ends up drunk!) Finally they emerge, jubilant, the chicken is tossed up on the roof. Whoever is able to catch it on its way down runs away with it, as it [237](#) mustn't stay in sight. (If

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people can catch the person who gets the chicken they may beat him.) As Baba Mwenda says, "That chicken, if the spirits were there with the initiate, and they brought him their wishes, well they won't bring them again, they will go with that chicken and he will remain behind, clean."

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¹⁶*Kuchagamka* = to be cheerful and social, a very important trait that is further discussed in Chapter 8.

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